

CURRICULUM VITAE

David Titus

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EDUCATION

Cornell University

PhD in Economics

Conferral August 2026

Master of Arts

December 2023

Binghamton University, State University of New York

Bachelor of Science in Economics

December 2019

Bachelor of Arts in Mathematics

December 2019

Summa cum laude

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Labor Economics, Economics of Immigration, Economics of Education

DISSERTATION COMMITTEE AND REFERENCES

Michèle Belot (Chair)

Frances Perkins Professor of Industrial and Labor Relations

Professor of Economics, Cornell University

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Francine Blau (Co-Chair)

Frances Perkins Professor Emeritus of Industrial and Labor Relations

Professor of Economics, Cornell University

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Lawrence Kahn (Committee Member)

Braunstein Family Professor Emeritus of Industrial and Labor Relations

Professor of Economics, Cornell University

lmk12@cornell.edu

Gary Fields (Teaching Assistant Supervisor)

The John P. Windmuller Professor Emeritus of International and Comparative Labor

Professor of Economics, Cornell University

gsf2@cornell.edu

AWARDS, HONORS, AND GRANTS

Sage Fellowship (Cornell University)

2025-2026

Graduate School Conference Travel Grant (Cornell University)

2025

Sage Fellowship (Cornell University)

2020-2021

Distinguished Achievement in Economics (Binghamton University)

2019

CURRENT RESEARCH

Job Market Paper

Immigration Policies and Human Capital: The Impact on Undocumented College Attendance

I estimate the impact of Universal E-Verify laws on the college attendance of undocumented Hispanics in the United States. To do so, I implement a series of event studies that account for staggered adoption over time, and I use a random forest algorithm as my primary approach for predicting undocumented status. My results indicate that Universal E-Verify laws lower the college attendance of undocumented Hispanics ages 18-24 by about 3.7 percentage points. This is a substantial effect: only 15.7 percent of undocumented Hispanics ages 18-24 in treated states were enrolled in college following the passage of the laws. This effect is robust to using logical imputation on non-citizen Hispanics to proxy for undocumented immigrants, using a logit model instead of random forest, testing for migration spillover effects on bordering states, and considering potentially confounding impacts of other state-level policies. I develop a theoretical model that explains the mechanisms through which Universal E-Verify affects college education, and I test this model's implications. I find suggestive evidence that the effect is driven by a negative labor market shock on undocumented adults ages 25-54, which likely leads to worse schooling for their children and renders college less attainable. These findings indicate that employment restrictions targeting working-age undocumented adults hinder the human capital development of undocumented youth.

Works in Progress

Market Structures, Prejudice, and the Residual Wage Gap between Refugees and Natives

I exploit regional variation in Germany to estimate the impact of labor market structures and prejudice on both the overall and residual wage and employment gaps between refugees and natives. I first demonstrate that persistent gaps exist even several years after refugee entry and after controlling for differences in education and demographics, and that large residual employment gaps remain after a decade. Much of the residual wage gap can be explained by heterogeneous returns to education: highly educated refugees receive substantially lower returns to their accumulated human capital than highly educated natives, indicating that firms may not value refugee credentials and that vocational training requirements in Germany may form a significant barrier. Furthermore, there exists significant variation by region, implying that certain local conditions are favorable or unfavorable for refugees. Using survey responses on social attitudes toward refugees, I do not find evidence that higher regional prejudice increases the wage gap. However, overall wage gaps and residual wage gaps are lower in regions with more binding minimum wages, while employment gaps are unaffected. I also find suggestive evidence that the overall wage gap is lower in regions with higher union coverage, and that residual wage gaps may be higher in regions with stronger vocational degree requirements for highly skilled workers. These results indicate that labor markets characterized by greater wage compression and fewer vocational training requirements are conducive to reducing refugee-native disparities.

Do Vocational Language Courses Improve Refugee Integration? Evidence from Germany

I estimate the dynamic impact of the German Vocational Language Course program (Berufssprachkurse or BSK, and formerly known as the ESF-BAMF course) on the employment and language skills of refugees in Germany. I further investigate whether the returns to the course are impacted by anti-refugee prejudice, and I also test for spillover effects within refugee households. Finally, propensity scores are used to generate overlap weights and estimate effects on the overlap population of refugees with similar treatment propensities. In the end, my event study results imply that the BSK increases fluency in German by 0.10 to 0.15 standard deviations compared to refugees who took only the basic language course. Furthermore, I find that participation is associated with substantial increases in employment probability that may become stronger several years after taking the course. There is also suggestive evidence that increased prejudice may reduce the marginal return to BSK. While there are only limited indications of within-household spillovers to German fluency, I do find evidence that refugees become less likely to be employed if someone else in the household partakes in BSK. These results imply that vocational language courses have remained an effective tool in improving refugee language acquisition and employment despite the large and sudden increase in asylum seekers from 2015 to 2018.

Gender Gaps: International Evidence on the Role of Family Policy

Ongoing project with Francine Blau, Lawrence Kahn, Leonardo Peñaloza-Pacheco, Freddy Bachmann, and Helen Burkhardt.

OTHER RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Cornell University Summer 2023 – Summer 2025
Graduate RA for Professor Francine Blau

Binghamton University, State University of New York Spring 2019 – Spring 2020
Undergraduate RA for Professor Plamen Nikolov

Cato Institute (Internship) Summer 2019

Past Research Assistant Projects

Skill Downgrading Among Refugees and Economic Immigrants in Germany: Evidence from the Syrian Refugee Crisis (IZA Discussion Paper No. 15426, July 2022)

With Plamen Nikolov and Leila Salarpour. Worked on project while an undergraduate RA at Binghamton University.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Introductory Microeconomics (ECON 1110, Cornell University) Winter 2024
Teaching Assistant for Senior Lecturer Jennifer Wissink

Economics of Wages and Employment (ILRLE 2400, Cornell University) Spring 2023
Teaching Assistant for Professor Gary Fields

Introductory Microeconomics (ECON 1110, Cornell University) Fall 2022
Teaching Assistant for Senior Lecturer Stephanie Thomas

Economics of Wages and Employment (ILRLE 2400, Cornell University) Spring 2022
Teaching Assistant for Professor George Jakubson

Public Finance (ECON 4260, Cornell University) Fall 2021
Teaching Assistant for Senior Lecturer Jennifer Wissink

Microeconomic Theory (ECON 360, Binghamton University) Fall 2018
Teaching Assistant for Professor David Slichter

OTHER TEACHING-RELATED EXPERIENCE

Grading Assistant (ECON 4260, Cornell University) Fall 2022, Fall 2023
Tutor in Economics and Mathematics (Varsity Tutors) Spring 2020
Tutor (Educational Opportunity Program, Binghamton University) Spring 2018 – Fall 2019

PRESENTATIONS

EEA-ESSM Congress, Dublin, IE (Scheduled) August 20, 2026
SOEP User Conference, Berlin, DE (Scheduled) July 8, 2026
Cornell Labor Work-in-Progress Seminar, Ithaca, NY Fall 2024, Spring 2025, Spring 2026
Midwest Economics Association, Chicago, IL March 20, 2026
APPAM Fall Research Conference, Seattle, WA November 14, 2025
Cornell Labor Economics Workshop, Ithaca, NY October 27, 2025
Midwest Economics Association, Kansas City, MO March 22, 2025

Academy of Economics and Finance, Pensacola, FL

February 13, 2025

PROGRAMMING: Stata, R, MATLAB, LaTeX